Gamification of Learning Kanji with "Musou Roman" Game

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***Abstract*— Japanese pop culture penetration in Indonesia, become lifestyles for many teenagers here. The fanatic fans of Japanese culture which are very dedicated to their Japanese related hobby, such as manga, anime or video games, is growing rapidly in numbers recently. They continually build a lot of communities that share the same interest of Japanese culture; therefore it is increasing interest of Japanese language as well. The purpose of this research is to study about how "Musou Roman" game can help Japan culture enthusiasts to learn the most complicated Japanese letters, kanji, beside katakana and hiragana letters through gamification. This paper examines the benefit of an RPG (Role-Playing Game) to learn other language and their complicated letters, in this case Japanese kanji. Suggestions for research are made, with particular reference to how gamification, can bridge learning outcomes as well as gameplay experience. This paper will contribute as potential solution to demystification in learning Japanese Kanji.**

Keywords—Gamification; Learning; Kanji; Japan; Pop; Culture; Role-Playing Game.

I. INTRODUCTION

The rising interest in foreign cultures, led to many opportunities to compete at global level, especially in competitions related to that cultures or languages. If not managed properly, some of the potential opportunities could be wasted. While the penetration of foreign culture to Indonesia is increasing the need for language proficiency of its culture. The rising of pop culture, especially J-pop and K-pop lead their language use to increased in youth segment. Right now Indonesia is one of the major countries that have highest interest in the world's most studying the language in Japan. As in the Survey Report Japanese Foundation in 2012, Indonesia has risen to be ranked number two after China in the category of most Japanese students. Ie by 21.8% when compared with 2009. The highest reasons to learn Japanese language is about 62.2% from their interest in Japanese Language, 54% from anime, manga, J-pop interest, and other Japanese modern culture, 49.7% from their interest in history and literature. Realizing that the interest in anime, manga, and is greater than the interest in the history, proves that modern Japanese culture in digital and traditional media are more influential as a starting point for someone to be interested in the Japanese language. [1] This growth of Japanese language interest is inseparable from the release of a lot of cartoons, comics, video games, technology, culture and also relationship between Japan and Indonesia.

Each year Japanese language enthusiasts is increasing, but the conventional teaching methods require new innovations to accommodate the needs of teaching and learning today. Several approaches started to be pursued to improve the quality of education especially in Japanese as Foreign Language (L2), to make learning more fun. As Gary Alan Fine said that fantasy games enthusiasts believed that such games have considerable educational potential, and it is easily seen that it can be used in school institution to teach folklore and mythology, or cultural differences even it is not designed for education need. [2] Therefore games are also tools to ease teaching & learning languages such as Japanese language.

In studying Japanese language learning, there are barriers that must be breached in order to strengthen the understanding. One of biggest obstacles, for both learners, the native language (L1), and the second language (L2) even more is learning kanji. As explained by Matsumoto that his research signs different developmental speeds and strategies in Japanese kanji reading between L2 learners of Japanese with L1 alphabetic knowledge and those with L1 kanji knowledge. [3] Hence, the author felt that media to ease Japanese language teaching, especially in studying kanji for second language learners is a need.

II. METHOD

Authors conducted literature observations, from journal to article that related to kanji learning and gamification. Direct observations with Japanese culture enthusiasts are conducted as pre assumption to search related materials.

III. LITERATURE REVIEW

A. Learning Kanji

When it comes to learning a culture, we can not eliminate the risk to learn the language from the country that producing the culture. Similarly, Japanese culture requires an understanding of the Japanese language to make it easier to

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absorb the culture they offer in many kind of media. The Japanese language has three types of letters, namely hiragana, katakana and kanji. While katakana and hiragana relatively more simple, Kanji has a high complexity because it consists of a 2000 typeface. Therefore learning kanji is a great challenge for learners of Japanese as a second language.

Based on Matsumoto research, that shows different developmental speeds and strategies in Japanese kanji reading it suggests a strong impact of L1 orthography on L2 reading development and strategy. Because L2 learners with L1 kanji knowledge have a different level of ability in reading kanji characters from those without L1 kanji knowledge, language teachers must provide well considered support in decoding texts. [3] Based on his research there should be a learning tool to facilitate decoding kanji letters easier.

B. Gamification

Negative perception of the game should be seen from the context. Showing positive side of the games such as enhance motivation, increase competitiveness, develop team communication, sharpen problem solving and decision making gives a wider perspective on how a game can have a positive influence rather than the opposite. Game, as Caillois define, that are non-productive and participation does not accomplish anything useful, must be excluded since non-productiveness does not go along with educational goals. Gamification is able to aid the proof of the contrary. [4]

Werbach define Gamification, as gameful design, is the use of elements and techniques from game design in non-game contexts. [5] Which means, game elements such as Points, Resource Collection, Progression, Levels, Quests, Avatars can be customized to teaching and learning purpose, while game techniques means that this learning tool as non-game context, is designed systematically, thoughtfully, artistically for the purpose of being fun just like games.

C. Role-Playing Games

Role-Playing Games, allows players to get into the fiction interactive story, which allows players to get quests, find the clues, communicating with the animated character in the game, and also get rewards in completion of tasks that has been given. Through imaginary animated character provides a level of distance between the subject matter and the student that allows him or her to explore society from a safer position. The result is a concrete understanding of classroom concepts; an informed understanding of the complexities and linkages of society; engaged, explorative classes; an awareness of the relationship between the individual and society; and a self-generated examination of preexisting beliefs about the self and society. [6]

RPG can become a useful tool for learning foreign language, because RPGs contain a considerable amount of language. In fact, the primacy of language in RPGs requires a lot of reading (and comprehension) in order to play them well – even to the extent that there are claims that the abundance and presentation of text in commercial RPGs (and adventure games) might create cognitive overload for L2 learners.[7] While Franciosi investigation was predicated on the assumption that increased use of RPG Simulator by educators would constitute a positive development in Foreign Language instruction in Japanese higher education. [8]

D. Otaku

The slang term otaku is witty reference both to someone who is not accustomed to close friendships and therefore tries to communicate with peers using this distant and overly formal form of address, and to someone who spends most of his or her time alone at home.[9] Amateur manga artists, referred to as manga otaku, were rapidly made into symbols of Japanese youth in general and took centers tage in the domestic social debate about the state of Japanese society that continued through the early 1990s. [9]

IV. DISCUSSION

A. Gamification Learning Kanji through "Musou Roman"

The main problem in learning kanji are inadequate teaching materials 28.5%, followed by insufficient interest Among Learners in the amount of 26.5%, and inadequate information on Japanese culture and society 23.9%. The results of this survey more response by the respondents from South East Asia.[6]

It is necessary to look for solutions so learning Kanji can be more easily understood, easy to remember, so the learning objectives can be more on target. Authors positioned "Musou Roman" to fill the lack traditional methods of learning kanji.

In order to realize the media gamification as a potential solution for learning languages. "Musou Roman" positioned as Japanese language based RPG Puzzle Game, because of learning Japanese language especially complex kanji letters, should be taught in an interesting and not boring, and easy to absorb. This IP is expected to facilitate and attract Indonesia teenagers attention to increase the use of the Japanese language later.

"Musou Roman" mobile games is targeting female otaku, the Japanese students, and mobile phone gamer as the main target, as Kawamura said that it is the girls who play a major role in Japanese subcultures. Japanese girls are always shopping, and they spend a great deal of their capital on clothes and makeup. Fashion is of the utmost importance for them because they want to stand out and be noticed. Some also wish to rebel against the formal and traditional ways. [10]

The female otaku love the visual style that fit like an animated image of Japan, and it would be better if you wear a full voice in the Japanese language itself because many female otaku have their own favorite voice dubber. Japanese students can enjoy this game as one of the media study them because this game is indirectly forcing them to memorize the finish line and kanji to win the game. This game will be played

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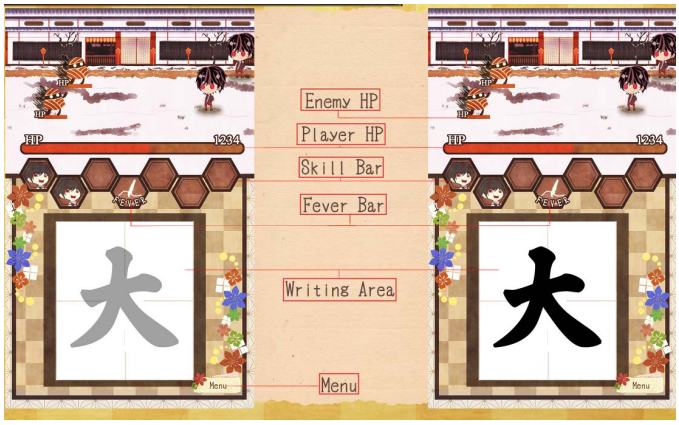
through smartphones and can be downloaded through the apps store.

According to the Global Mobile Game Industry White Book, the mobile target spenders, in Southeast Asia, especially in the six major countries (Indonesia, Malaysia, Philippines, Thailand, Vietnam) are willing to spend the money for games with five reasons: 1. Make the play becomes more interesting and exciting, 2. Opening an extra level, 3. Competitive advantage, 4. Pursuit other players level, 5. Avoid cool down time or wait.[11] Although many are playing just to spend time, many of them were competing for a higher level of their friends. The higher the level is reached, the higher their satisfaction.

While according to Casual Games Sector Report 2015, Indonesia has a large percentage of spending money on mobile games. The primary key of the sale of these games is because of the young population as the trigger of the consumptive nature. Indonesia is also included among the countries most largest population in Southeast Asia. Most of these live in urban circles, especially Jakarta as a city with a large population. Their large growth in the middle class and the growth of mobile internet enables a large investment in mobile games in Indonesia. As many as 49% of mobile gamers spend money on mobile games and most prefer the strategy game genre. [12]

"Musou Roman" designed as the other RPG game, but there are some things adjusted to the needs of learning kanji.

Some elements were made by gaming elements such as: Points in the form of achievements points, resource collection in HP (Health Point) form, customizable avatars, level in skill bar form, quests as task to memorize the kanji to the finish line and win the game. While Social Graphs will be shows via social media and websites so users can view the latest news events and news can be seen on the website.



V. Conclusions

As we mention earlier, that one of the the greatest difficulty in learning Japanese language is learning Kanji, because there were so many, even up to 2000 letters, other causes are because of inadequate teaching materials, insufficient interest among learners and inadequate information on Japanese culture and society. If only the material being taught using instructional media in the form they like, such as games and adapted to the targeted segments, can be obtained educational objectives and purpose of generating revenue.

Therefore authors create "Musou Roman" to help students develop their skill to learn effectively. Through RPG mobile games, we expect it can be as altenate solution to help student learn kanji letters.

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